M365-13 · Legacy File Share Retirement & Migration Runbook

How legacy network drives are retired without losing content, scattering it into personal OneDrives, or breaking payroll access on the way.

Field	Value
Document ID	M365-13
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	A. Microsoft 365
Operating tier	Tier 3 — Expert Services. Per-share execution is Tier 2; the migration itself is Tier 3 protected capacity (GOV-06 §8).
Review cycle	Monthly while the migration is live, then retire this document when the drives are gone.
Related existing policy	Your organization's network shared storage policy, if one exists. This runbook executes its retirement; the policy will need revising or retiring once the drives are gone.

1. Purpose

When legacy network drives (the classic Z: and Y: mapped drives) are retired, this document is the procedure for doing that without losing content, without scattering it into individual OneDrives, and without breaking access to things people need on a Tuesday morning.

It exists because the first department to ask what the retirement means for them — often HR, asking about payroll access — usually gets a conversation rather than a document. That conversation can go well. The next twelve go better with a runbook.

2. Three rules that govern the whole migration

> **Rule 1 — The destination exists before the source goes.**
> A share is not switched off until its replacement site is live, classified, permissioned, and holding the content. Not “planned”. Live.
> The failure this prevents is specific and predictable: when a familiar shared location disappears and no replacement is obvious, people move its contents into their own OneDrive. A shared departmental store silently becomes a set of private ones, which is a worse outcome than the drives staying (M365-12 §8).

> **Rule 2 — Classify before you migrate.**
> The destination site is classified under M365-15 before content lands in it. Classifying afterwards means the content sits unclassified for however long "afterwards" turns out to be, and in practice that is permanent.
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> This migration is the largest classification opportunity the organization will get. Taking it costs one extra question per share.

> **Rule 3 — Nothing is deleted.**
> The drives are made read-only, then dark, then decommissioned — but the data is retained until the migration is verified complete and signed off. Deletion is a separate, later, deliberate act.
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> A migration that deletes as it goes has no way back from a mistake nobody noticed for three weeks.

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3. Before anything moves — the inventory

This is the part that gets skipped and the part that determines whether the migration is six weeks or six months.

1. List every top-level share on the drives being retired, with its size, file count, and the date of its most recently modified file. The last of those is the most useful number on the list.
2. For each share, identify a departmental owner — a named person, not a department. Where nobody can be found, that share goes to §6.
3. Classify each share with its owner under M365-15. One question: what is the most sensitive thing in here?
4. Record the current access: which groups and individuals, and at what level. This is the input to §5 and it will not be clean.
5. Flag anything with a last-modified date older than three years. Much of it is genuinely dead, and migrating it costs the same as migrating live content.
6. Flag anything containing a system of record extract — payroll spreadsheets, exports from the HR and user system of record. These may not need migrating at all (§7).
7. Produce the migration order. Smallest and simplest first, so the runbook is proven before it meets payroll.

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4. Per-share runbook

4.1 Prepare (T-10 days)

1. Create the destination site under M365-10, with the named owner and the classification from §3.
2. Build the permission groups per M365-11 §2, translating the existing access per §5. Do not replicate individual grants.
3. Agree with the owner what is not coming: dead content, duplicates, system-of-record extracts. Every file that does not move is a file that never has to be governed again.

4. Tell the department: what is moving, when, where it will be, and that the old drive stays readable for a period afterwards.

4.2 Migrate (T-3 to T-0)

1. Copy — do not move — the content into the destination site. The source stays intact.
2. Verify: file counts and total size match, and the owner confirms a sample of what they actually use is present and openable.
3. Fix what did not survive: long paths, illegal characters, files locked open. Expect some; they are normal and they are the reason for the verification step.
4. Run both in parallel for at least one full working week. The source is still authoritative during this period and people are told so.

4.3 Cut over

1. Make the source share read-only. This is the moment the destination becomes authoritative, and it is reversible.
2. Re-sync anything changed during the parallel week.
3. Leave it read-only for four weeks. Somebody will need something and this is much cheaper than a restore.
4. Make the source dark — inaccessible but retained. Tell the department the date.
5. The owner signs off that the share is complete and correct. Record it.

4.4 After

1. Remove the mapped drive from group policy or the login script for that department, so nobody sees a broken drive letter for months afterwards. This is the step most often forgotten and the one users notice most.
2. Update any documentation, shortcut or bookmark that pointed at the old path.
3. Record the share as complete in the migration register.

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5. Translating drive permissions into site permissions

Drive ACLs and SharePoint groups are not the same shape, and a literal translation produces an unmanageable site. Translate the intent, not the mechanism.

On the drive	Do not	Do
A department group with Modify	Recreate the same AD group as a site permission and stop thinking.	Map it to Site Members. Check with the owner that everybody in it still needs edit rather than read.
Individuals with explicit access	Recreate each one individually.	Ask the owner why each exists. Most are historical. The rest belong in a group.
A subfolder with different access	Break inheritance to reproduce it.	Make it a second site (M365-11 §5). This is the single most valuable simplification in the migration.

On the drive	Do not	Do
Read-only access for a wide group	Assume it is unnecessary.	Map to Site Visitors. Wide read access is usually right and it prevents edit-access requests.
Access nobody can explain	Carry it forward “to be safe”.	Leave it out and tell the owner you have. If somebody needs it, they will say so within a fortnight and you will have learned why it existed.

A migration is the only moment when trimming access costs nothing politically, because everything is changing anyway. Use it.

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6. Content nobody owns

Every file share migration finds shares whose owner has left, whose department has been reorganised, or which nobody recognises. This is normal and it needs a decision path rather than a pause.

1. Look at the last-modified date. Nothing touched in three years is a candidate for archive rather than migration.
2. Ask the department that most plausibly owns it. Give them two weeks and one reminder.
3. Where somebody claims it, they become the owner and it follows §4 normally.
4. Where nobody claims it, it goes to a single Unclaimed Archive site, classified CONFIDENTIAL as a precaution, with Tier 4 as owner and access on request.
5. It is not deleted. Retention on that archive is a Tier 4 and records decision, not a migration decision, and it can be taken calmly later.

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7. The payroll and HR case

This is the share that prompted the question, and it deserves its own treatment because it is the highest-consequence one.

- Payroll content is CONFIDENTIAL at minimum. Anything containing social security numbers is RESTRICTED (M365-15 §3).
- The first question is not where it moves but whether it moves. A payroll extract in a spreadsheet is a copy of something already held safely in the payroll system. Where the system of record can serve the need, the right migration is a deletion after confirmation — with HR agreeing, and after the retention position is checked.
- What genuinely must persist as files goes to a site classified accordingly, with an HR owner, named membership, and no inherited access from anywhere.
- Access is granted afresh rather than translated. This is the one share where §5’s “carry nothing forward you cannot explain” is absolute.
- HR signs off the destination permissions before content moves, not after.
- Run this share last, after the runbook has been proven on five ordinary ones.

> **And answer the question that was actually asked**
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> When HR asks whether the drives are really going away, the answer they need in writing is: yes, and here is the date; your content will be at this address; these named people will have access; nothing is deleted in the process; and the old drive stays readable for four weeks after the move.
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> Five facts. Most anxiety about a migration is anxiety about not knowing those five things.

8. Communicating it

When	What the department is told
At inventory	That their share is in scope, who IT thinks owns it, and a request to confirm.
T-10 days	The date, the destination address, what is not coming and why, and who to ask.
At cutover	The destination is now the live copy. The old drive is read-only until a named date.
Going dark	The date the old drive disappears, sent at least a week ahead.
Complete	A short confirmation, and the removal of the mapped drive so nothing broken lingers.

Every message says where things are now and who to ask. A migration notice that explains the project rather than the destination has failed at its only job.

9. Decommissioning

1. All shares migrated and signed off by their owners.
2. Unclaimed content in the archive site.
3. Mapped drives removed from every login script and policy.
4. A final read-only period across the whole volume, four weeks, after the last share.
5. Backup of the volume retained per the retention decision, independent of the live drives.
6. Servers decommissioned under GOV-04 as a change, not as a migration task.
7. Revise or retire the network shared storage policy, which describes drives that will no longer exist. Retire this runbook at the same time (GOV-01 §11).

10. Service levels

Activity	Commitment (per GOV-06)
Migration work generally	Tier 3 protected capacity, not queue work (GOV-06 §8).
“I cannot find a file that used to be on the old drive”	P2 — 4 coverage hours. Highest-priority category during migration.
Owner sign-off request	Two weeks, one reminder, then escalate to their manager.
A share whose owner cannot be found	§6. Two weeks, one reminder, then the archive.

Activity	Commitment (per GOV-06)
Cutover window	Declared under GOV-04. Tier 2 and Tier 3 go to Degraded for its duration (GOV-06 §7).

11. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
Migration register: share, owner, classification, size, dates, status	Project record	Life of migration + 3 years
Owner sign-off per share	Project record	7 years
Permission translation decisions, including what was deliberately not carried forward	Project record	7 years
HR sign-off on the payroll destination	Project record	7 years
Unclaimed content inventory	Tier 4 record	Until the archive is dispositioned

12. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
Storage Policy	Your organization's network shared storage policy	Describes what is being retired. Revise or retire at §9.
M365-15	Data Classification & Handling	Rule 2. Classification before migration.
M365-10	SharePoint Site Request, Provisioning & Ownership	Creates every destination.
M365-11	SharePoint & OneDrive Permission Management	§5 translation, and the second-site preference.
M365-12	OneDrive Appropriate Use	Rule 1 — the failure this prevents.
M365-16	Retention, Legal Hold & eDiscovery	Retention of the archive and the backups.
GOV-04	IT Change Management & Maintenance Windows	Cutover windows and decommissioning.
GOV-06	Service Commitments	§10, and protected capacity.

Appendix A — Per-share checklist

✓	Step	Evidence
☐	Named owner identified and confirmed	Owner name

✓	Step	Evidence
☐	Classified under M365-15 with the owner	Level
☐	Current access recorded	Access export
☐	Dead content and system-of-record extracts agreed out of scope	Exclusion list
☐	Destination site created, classified, permissioned	Site URL
☐	Department told: date, destination, what is not coming, who to ask	Notice sent
☐	Content COPIED, source intact	Copy complete
☐	Counts and size verified; owner confirmed a sample opens	Verification note
☐	Parallel running for one full working week	Dates
☐	Source made read-only; changes re-synced	Date
☐	Read-only period of four weeks observed	End date
☐	Owner signed off complete and correct	Sign-off
☐	Source made dark, department told the date in advance	Date
☐	Mapped drive removed from login script / policy	Confirmed
☐	Documentation and shortcuts updated	Confirmed
☐	Register updated	Status: complete

Appendix B — What to tell people

Five facts. Most migration anxiety is not knowing them.

Yes, it is going away	And here is the date. Not “soon”.
Here is where your files will be	A link, not a description.
Here is who will have access	The named list, so you can tell us now if it is wrong.
Nothing is being deleted	The old drive goes read-only first, and stays readable for four weeks.
Here is who to ask	A person and the service desk. Not “IT”.

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.